

ence for all genres of music, the way the artist truly intended. Consumers can also change the bit rate to suit their wireless environment. We have some exciting product launch coming up for music creators, so stay tuned.

Q The Active Noise Cancellation space has typically been dominated by Sony. How does Sony stay ahead of the curve?

A We launched the much-hyped 1000X series in 2016, and since then we have worked continuously to stay ahead of the curve, in developing processors and continuously upholding the leadership position of being the industry leading Noise Cancellation headphones till date with the latest WH-1000XM5. The predecessors to the Sony's WH-1000XM5 were king of the hill and this new headphone takes that crown. With new drivers, features and design, the Sony WH-1000XM5 is an intriguing set of headphones among the flagship active noise cancelling (ANC) devices in the market. It excels in travel and office use case scenario. There is a potential for Noise Cancellation Headphones in the Indian market as we have witnessed a huge surge in travel and hybrid working. Noise Cancellation supports work from home environment and learn from home, also to watch OTT content and listen to music and immerse in technologies like 360RA, DSEE, Hi-Res Audio with our most popular 1000X, LS900 and C500 series.

Q What technological developments in 2022 have helped ensure the improved quality of audio products from Sony?

A We have recently launched premium soundbar in 2022, named A-series which includes flagship products like HT-A9, HT-A7000, HT-A5000 and HT-A3000. These soundbars utilize Sony's revolutionary 360 Spatial Sound Mapping technology which creates up to twelve phantom speakers. Our A-Series soundbars have a versatile layout to suit any kind of living room, there is no need to re-arrange furniture or to precisely position speakers. There is a built-in microphone in each speaker which ingeniously measures

the relative height and position, judge the atmosphere and allows the system to generate 12 phantom speakers and completely encircle the room in immersive spatial sound. In addition, it has vertical Surround Engine and S-force Pro Front sound which helps to generate even more immersives vertical and surround sound.

Q The Sony Linkbuds were a design departure from Sony. Can you let us know about the response for these earbuds in India specifically?

A LinkBuds have been developed based on the concept of proposing a new sound experience of 'always-on' sound gateway, that connects the online and real world. Real sounds are the sounds that you hear when you are talking with your family on a daily basis or the surrounding sounds that you hear while walking, which supports always staying connected with both worlds, online, and offline.

The design of the LinkBuds is dominated by a large hole in the middle of the earbuds. It comes in white and grey colors and the entire bud looks like a ring attached to a small pod. The ring portion houses a

specially designed ring-shaped driver while the pod houses the battery and electronics. In keeping with Sony's sustainability efforts, the shell of the LinkBuds is made from recycled automotive plastic and has a speckled pattern. Wearing them and listening to music feels like one has got personal background music being piped into the ears all the time. The LinkBuds are likely to appeal most to customers who want to stay connected with music and the real world.

Q What is your favourite piece of technology from 2022? Any personal stories you can share about your experience with the latest tech of last year?

A I work in hybrid mode and in my free time, I like to stay at home to enjoy movies with my family. Without a doubt, my favorite technology is 360SSM as with one soundbar, HT-A5000, my living room gives me a truly immersive cinematic experience. When we enjoy our favorite movie content, 360 immersive theatre experience sound comes from all directions. For example, while watching a movie with this new sensation of sound, I can experience all the action and drama and hear every breath, which feels like I am inside the film. I would like to deliver this immersive theatre experience to Indian customers to enjoy their favorite content at home.

Q Did the global chip shortage in 2022 affect Sony since many audio devices come with an onboard chip for AI processing? Has the situation worsened or gotten better?

A The semiconductor shortage is a global phenomenon that has impacted various businesses and industries for the foreseeable future, and India is no exception. However, we have sufficient inventories for the home entertainment segment, such as soundbars and party speakers, to maintain the supply chain without any disruption in the near future. However, we are closely monitoring the global situation in terms of economic conditions as well as any supply-related issues whether semiconductors or logistics. **d**

"We launched the much-hyped 1000X series in 2016, and since then we have worked continuously to stay ahead of the curve..."

Shohei Toyoda
Head of Audio Business
at Sony India

